3.1.1 Earth's magnetic field and magnetic elements

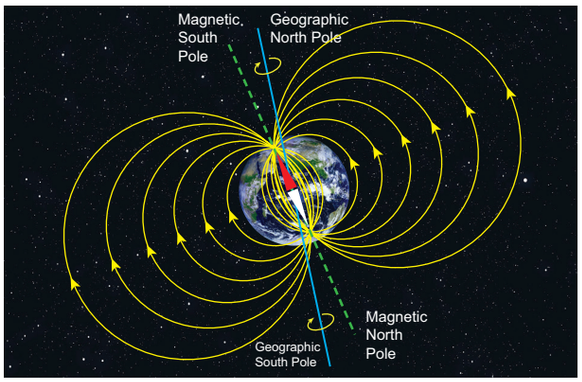


Figure 3.3 Earth's magnetic field

From the activities performed in lower classes, you might have noticed that the needle in a magnetic compass or freely suspended magnet comes to rest in a position which is approximately along the geographical north-south direction of the Earth.

DO YOU KNOW?

William Gilbert in 1600 proposed that Earth itself behaves like a gigantic powerful bar magnet. But this theory is not successful because the temperature inside the Earth is very high and so it will not be possible for a magnet to retain its magnetism.

Gover suggested that the Earth's magnetic field is due to hot rays coming out from the Sun. These rays will heat up the air near equatorial region. Once air becomes hotter, it rises above and will move towards northern and southern hemispheres and get electrified. This may be responsible to magnetize the ferromagnetic materials near the Earth's surface. Till date, so many theories have been proposed. But none of the theorium completely explains the cause for the Earth's magnetism.

The north pole of magnetic compass needle is attracted towards the magnetic south pole of the Earth which is near the geographic north pole (Figure 3.3). Similarly, the south pole of magnetic compass needle is attracted towards the magnetic north-pole of the Earth which is near the geographic south pole. **The branch of physics which deals with the Earth's magnetic field is called Geomagnetism or Terrestrial magnetism.**

There are three quantities required to specify the magnetic field of the Earth on its surface, which are often called as the elements of the Earth's magnetic field. They are

(a) magnetic declination (D)

(b) magnetic dip or inclination (I)

(c) the horizontal component of the Earth's magnetic field (B_H)

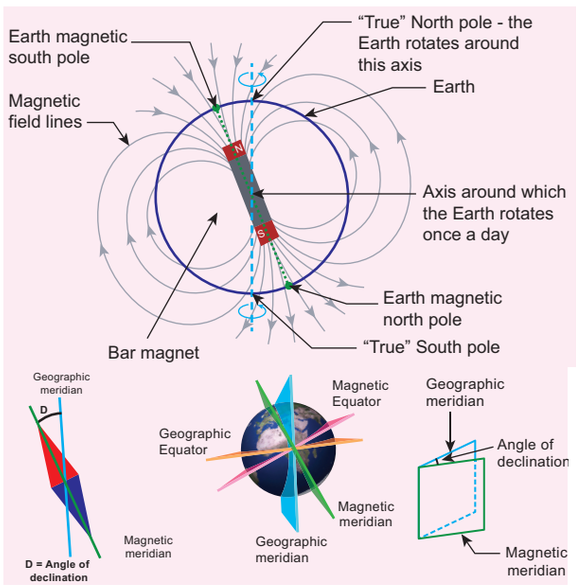


Figure 3.4 Declination angle

Day and night occur because Earth spins about an axis called geographic axis. A vertical plane passing through the geographic axis is called geographic meridian and a great circle perpendicular to Earth's geographic axis is called geographic equator.

The straight line which connects magnetic poles of Earth is known as magnetic axis.

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